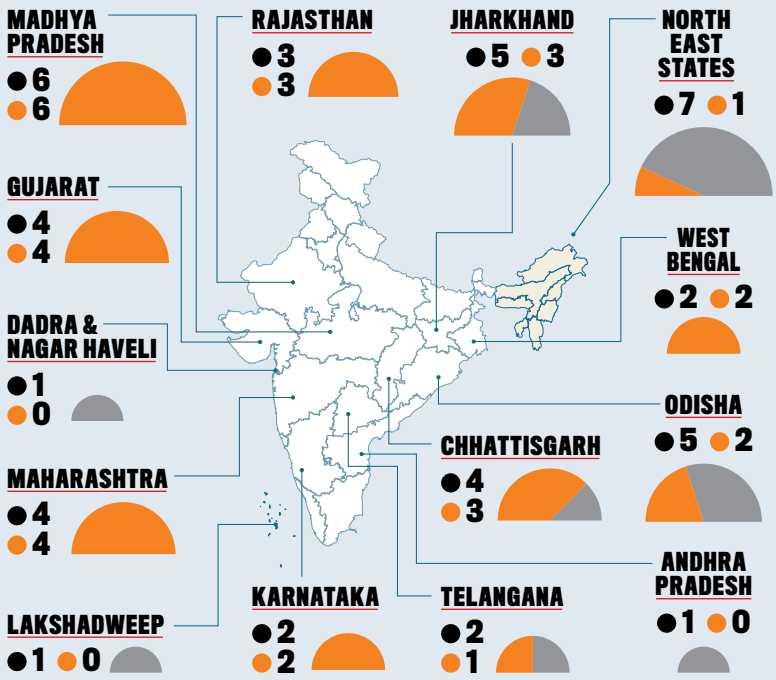
THE SAFFRON HEFT

The BJP won 31 of the 47 reserved tribal LS seats in 2019



Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

WHAT THE TRIBALS FEAR

- That the Constitution will be modified to remove reservations for STs
- Uniform Civil Code (UCC) will take away their privileges
- Displacement and forced migration due to loss of land to infrastructure/ industrial projects, resultant loss of identity and way of life, culture
- Access to affordable education in their habitats
- 'Converted' Christian tribals being excluded from the government quota
- Pastoral nomadic tribes in Maharashtra, Gujarat getting ST status
- Slow implementation of Forest Rights Act

a better life. Many try the competitive exams route, but only a handful succeed. They return to their village seeking white-collar jobs, but finally end up taking to farming or starting small village shops."

A big perception battle the BJP is fighting is over the controversial Forest (Conservation) Amendment Act, 2023, which came into force in December last. The changes, which allegedly makes it easier for authorities to divert forest areas for commercial and public infrastructure purposes, could be a deal-breaker with sections of the tribal community who still live on the fringes of jungles. The party has tried to soften the blow in states where it rules, like Chhattisgarh for instance, by hiking the wages and bonus for tendu leaf pluckers (most of whom are tribals) and other means such as backing out of the controversial amendments to the COTPA (Cigarettes and Other Tobacco Products Act).

Of course, the Modi government also has a trump card in President Murmu, the first tribal president of the country. The party is hoping it will swing votes in home state Odisha (the First Citizen is from Rairangpur in Mayurbhanj district).

Sound the Poll Bugle

Poll trends seem to suggest that the BJP is on a good wicket in the tribal seats, especially with the recent assembly election victories in the tribal heartland states of Chhattisgarh, MP, Rajasthan and Gujarat. The Congress is the main opposition in all four states, but all indications suggest they may be a bit stretched. In fact, in almost all the seats in these states, the BJP's main challenge comes from the young firebrands, relegating Congress veterans to the backburner.

Take Gujarat, for instance, where the BJP has swept all four tribal seats since 2014 and appears set for a repeat. Two young tribal MLAs—AAP's Chaitar Vasava, the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) candidate in Bharuch, and the Congress's Valsad candidate Anant Patel—are hoping to spoil the BJP's party. Chaitar is pitched against six-term MP Mansukh Vasava, while Anant is up against Dhaval Patel, the national social media in-charge of the BJP's Tribal Morcha.

The other formation creating quite a stir is the Bharat Adivasi Party (BAP), which won seats in both MP (1) and Rajasthan (3) in the recent state elections. BAP's rise—and its popularity among young tribal voters—has coincided with a general feeling that mainstream political